NASM VIRTUAL COACHING SPECIALIST (VCS)

Chapter 8: Selling Virtual Coaching

National Academy of Sports Medicine — Evidence-Based Telehealth Curriculum

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching
Lesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and Packaging

It may seem counterintuitive, but many companies lose sales because they try to provide solutions for everyone instead of focusing on a smaller, yet profitable market. Understanding individual expertise and personal goals will help fitness professionals develop a niche, unique selling proposition, and pricing model to differentiate from the competition and drive sales.

Learning Objectives

After completing this chapter, the NASM Virtual Coach will have the ability to do the following:

- **Identify** customer problems to develop sales strategy.
- **Summarize** how to develop and customize sales goals.
- **Describe** the sales process.
- **Summarize** the customer journey process.
- **Create** a prospecting strategy.

Introduction

Without sales, any business will cease to exist. A fitness professional who owns their own business must give careful thought and consideration to the best methods to sell virtual coaching. Sales can be intimidating and can even sometimes have a negative connotation, but it does not have to be this way. Many new business owners assume that sales will come naturally; however, this is rarely the case. Much like helping clients achieve goals, sales require training, systems, processes, and consistent practice to yield results for the business. Sales are an outcome of a repeatable and scalable process. Without a well-developed sales process, sales will likely never come. A virtual fitness professional must develop scalable, teachable, and repeatable processes to help their businesses grow to become a successful entrepreneur (**Figure: Fitness Professional Entrepreneur**).



FigureFitness Professional Entrepreneur

When starting a traditional or virtual business, the fitness professional is typically not only a **business owner** but also a **business operator**, spending their hours and efforts working both *in the business* and working *on the business*. However, being a business owner-operator should not be the end goal, as this model is likely not sustainable. The end goal of the business-owning fitness professional should be to become a true entrepreneur. An entrepreneur does not simply own or operate a business, they *run* a business. The entrepreneur works diligently to create clear and efficient business and sales processes. They utilize and leverage automation so they can focus on other aspects of their business. They value positive and negative feedback. Entrepreneurs strive for not only improving their business but improving themselves.

This chapter will provide the fitness business entrepreneur with tools necessary to build a successful sales program that will be repeatable, largely automated, and will scale with their business as it grows. When applicable, each section will contain a writing prompt with at least three questions to help the entrepreneur develop a reliable sales strategy for their business.

Coach's Corner

Please note: At the end of each section there are three or more writing prompts to help the fitness professional develop their own well-thought-out and detailed sales plan. The sales plan prompts should be completed after reading the entire chapter, as many of these questions and ideas work off each

other. To develop a complete picture of what the fitness professional's sales plan will look like, it is important to understand all of the concepts presented in this chapter first.

Business owner

An individual or group who owns a business entity and has final decision-making authority as well as first right to profits.

Business operator

The individual running the day-to-day operations of a business.

Defining Sales

Purchasing is a solution to a problem. When **consumers** have an issue or unmet need, they typically purchase a product or service they feel will solve that specific problem or meet that specific need. As soon as the transaction is complete, the company this product or service was purchased from has *made a sale*. Selling a product or service is problem solving. Consequently, sales are the process of truthfully and successfully conveying that a company's product or service offering truly solves the consumer's problem.

Fitness business entrepreneurs take on many different duties, especially when starting and growing their business. One of the most important tasks a virtual fitness business entrepreneur will have is that of a salesperson. As previously mentioned, without sales, a company will cease to exist. Many business owners, and people in general, have an aversion to sales. Salespeople are sometimes viewed as manipulative and willing to do whatever it takes to make a sale—even at the customer's expense. The stereotypical salesperson shows little regard for the interest of the customer and cares more about getting money in their pocket. In contrast, the fitness business entrepreneur is not a stereotypical salesperson and will not be viewed as such, provided they have a long-term mindset about their business and emphasize putting their customers' interests first. Fitness business entrepreneurs generally are passionate about the product or service they offer and believe it will make a significant impact on their client's life. By putting ethics and clients' interests first, there is no need to worry about coming across as a manipulative or unethical salesperson. While it probably does not need to be stated, manipulation and poor ethics do not produce results in the long run.

As many retail and financial transactions now take place via e-commerce web and mobile applications, prospective clients will also likely expect a virtual coaching business to conduct its sales online. Leveraging the familiarity that potential clients already have with e-commerce, automated sales processes can be developed by the fitness professional that will turn their business into a smooth-running sales machine.

Inbound and Outbound Sales

Sales can be divided into two categories: inbound sales and outbound sales. **Outbound sales** are sales initiated by the business—in other words, the business contacted the client first to attempt a sale. Outbound sales are associated with techniques such as cold calling, where the business contacts prospective clients unsolicited.



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Conversely, **inbound sales** are sales initiated by the client—in other words, the client contacted the business looking to purchase a particular product or service.

The virtual fitness professional's customer acquisition strategy should be built around an inbound sales approach. Inbound prospective clients include those who have found the business via content-driven platforms like social media channels, blogs, videos, podcasts, etc. Inbound strategies are centered on establishing trust and building rapport with prospective customers. Successful inbound methods help establish the brand as a trusted advisor through high-quality content. By earning prospective clients' trust and interest they will be more receptive to sales tools the fitness professional entrepreneur will utilize to generate business, such as automated e-mail marketing. With that in mind, this chapter will focus primarily on inbound sales processes.

Consumer

Individuals in the target audience who are not yet aware of the business or its products and services.

Outbound sales

Sales that are initiated by the business; the business contacted the consumer first.

Inbound sales

Sales that are initiated by the consumer; the consumer contacted the business first.

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching
Lesson 1Introduction to Sales, Pricing, and Packaging

Why People Make Purchases

Consumers purchase products or services to solve a problem. When clients and potential clients are not satisfied with their current health and fitness or are not attaining their desired fitness and health goals, they typically seek out goods and services to help fulfill that desire. For the virtual fitness professional, most of their clients will have similar goals, including weight loss, building muscle, obtaining better overall health, improving performance, etc. The fitness professional's mission is to identify the problems their clients are facing, inform the client how their programs and services can help solve their problem, and ethically guide the future client in their purchase of the business's services (**Figure: Fitness Professional's Mission**).



FigureFitness Professional's Mission

Identify the Problem

Utilizing the target market identified in their business plan, the fitness professional has a well-defined market audience. Correctly identifying the specific problems clients are seeking to solve is key to developing a successful **sales funnel**. Note that a client's problem or problems may change over time. It is always important to obtain feedback on how the goods and services are meeting the needs of the target market, not only from clients but also from potential clients who do not currently purchase the service.

When starting a business, the fitness professional does not always have enough, or any, feedback from their potential market. To solve this, the fitness professional must conduct market research to understand the most common challenges prospective clients are facing. At this stage, the fitness professional may not have clients or even potential clients whom they can contact for useful feedback, but they can still develop an idea based on their own knowledge and experience about what problems and challenges the market needs to solve and overcome. The focus of the initial sales strategy should be the problems that currently exist in the market that inspired the fitness professional to develop their own virtual fitness business.

Sales Strategy Questions for Identifying the Problem



A useful exercise is to ask a series of questions to progressively narrow down the focus and help identify the primary problem future programs and services will solve.

1. What are three problems that everyone, not just the target customer, faces that makes them seek out the expertise and guidance of a fitness professional?
2. What are two problems (same as above or otherwise) that virtual coaching solves for clients compared to traditional in-person training?
3. What is one problem that is unique to your target market that you feel you can solve better than anyone else?

Sales funnel

An organized, repeatable process that a prospective customer follows to become a paid customer.

Solve the Problem

With the problem identified, and the fitness professional already having established that they can solve the problem with their service, the next step is to understand how to successfully communicate the problem and solution to a potential client. Advertising and marketing are the keys to conveying this message.



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Marketing and sales are closely related, and advertisements are an integral part of sales. Advertisements typically convey solutions to identified problems. Consider television ads for soft drinks. They largely focus on people relaxing, quenching their thirst, and cooling off with an ice-cold drink. The problem is thirst and the solution is the soft drink. If an ad for a soft drink stated, "You're going to be thirsty sometime, and when you are, buy our drink," the advertisement would not have much impact. However, if the advertisement clearly demonstrates how the product can fix a problem, the impact is much greater. When attempting to convey that a product solves a problem, the fitness professional should be mindful to not only highlight the obvious solution but also focus on the reasons why the problem exists in the first place.

Sales Strategy Questions for Solving the Problem



1. What are three reasons, or subproblems, why your target market's problem exists?
2. What is a solution for each of the three subproblems identified?
3. Construct a paragraph of **sales copy** that conveys the overall problem, subproblems, and solution.

Sales copy

Writing with the specific goal of guiding a consumer through a sale.

Emotional Factors in Purchasing

Consumers buy products and services for a variety of reasons. The Consumer Emotional Intelligence Scale (Kidwell et al., 2008) was designed to investigate the role that emotional factors play in consumer's purchasing decisions. The three emotional factors examined include self-concept connection, emotional attachment, and brand love. This study found focusing on emotional connections with consumers, rather than traditional features and benefits, resulted in greater brand loyalty. For the fitness entrepreneur, this should be the main focus of the sales strategy. When attempting to build an emotional connection with customers, authenticity is essential, with 81% of consumers stating they must be able to trust a brand (Edelman, 2019).

With a solid understanding of the problems their programs and services solve, the virtual fitness professional can put themselves in their clients' and prospective clients' shoes and imagine the emotions that they may feel about the problems they are experiencing. Selling based on emotions is not an attempt to take advantage of the negative emotions people feel due to a certain problem but to highlight the positive emotions a person will feel when they realize the fitness entrepreneur's product solves the problem.

Sales Plan Questions for Emotional Factors in Purchasing



1. What is one negative emotion a consumer feels for each of the subproblems identified in the previous section?
2. What are two possible positive emotions for each subproblem once solved?
3. How does the client feel prior to utilizing the service? What positive emotions will be revealed once the services are delivered? (Write a detailed paragraph.)

Prices and Packages

When pricing a core product, a fitness professional must ensure their pricing aligns with the target market being served. A very low-priced service being offered to high-income earners will have a difficult time finding clients who value the service. A service whose target market is seniors on a fixed income may not find clients if the service is priced too high. The pricing level of a product should not be confused with the quality or value of a product. A product can be economically priced but of high quality and value, and conversely, a luxury priced product can be of very poor quality and not offer much value.

Pricing Strategies

The business plan should define the target market and provide a pricing analysis of competitors in the market. The virtual fitness professional should set the base price of the service in the range of market analysis. Once the base price of a product is set, the fitness professional can then use different pricing strategies to aid in the sales process. The four pricing strategies discussed in *Chapter 2: Building a Business* include economy, skimming, penetration, and premium pricing. Additionally, the fitness professional may also consider using promotional pricing and bundle pricing strategies (**Figure: Pricing Strategies**).

Penetration pricing is used to build interest in a new product. With this method, the standard price of the product is initially reduced as an introductory offering. However, this pricing strategy may result in a price so low the business cannot sustain selling at this rate for long periods of time. When penetration pricing is used, a clear objective, or cut-off, must be noted. Penetration pricing objectives may include initially obtaining a specific number of clients, converting those clients to higher-priced programs or services, increasing client referrals, or having a specific and publicly announced end date for the promotion.



FigurePricing Strategies



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Promotional pricing is similar to penetration pricing but with a few distinct differences. First, promotional pricing is offered to an existing product or service. Second, the discount should not be as low as a penetration pricing discount. With an existing and established product, offering a very large discount runs the risk of upsetting existing customers, along with devaluing the services that are provided. If a product or service is regularly on sale, most customers will wait until promotional pricing is offered again, rather than purchase at the standard price.

Bundle pricing is a strategy that offers discounts for buying in bulk. This can either be buying one product in bulk or purchasing multiple products together for a discounted price. For example, different bundle discounts could be offered on monthly coaching if a client pre-pays for 3, 6, or 12 months of coaching when compared to paying monthly. A bundle discount for clients who purchase multiple products would cover clients who purchased fitness training and nutrition coaching together instead of purchasing fitness training or nutrition coaching alone.

Training Packages

The fitness professional does not need to have a one-size-fits-all approach to their packages. While a price point for the business is set in the business plan (economy, midgrade, or luxury), programs and services offered can still fall within a range of those price points. Providing different options to target the different needs of clients will allow a business to offer more personalized solutions to clients' specific needs and desires.

For each product developed, the entrepreneur can easily create and establish three price levels for that program or service, with each price level offering more or fewer features.

Online Fitness Coaching Packages

Level/Cost Per Month	Monthly Training Program	Bi-Weekly E-Mail Check-Ins With Coach	Weekly E-Mail Check-Ins With Coach	Monthly 30-Minute Video Check-In
Good / $149	X	X		
Better / $199	X		X	
Best / $250	X		X	X

The example provided in **Table: Online Fitness Coaching Packages** illustrates that simply changing from a coaching check-in every other week to every week, results in a $50 a month upgrade, or a 20% increase in price. On the other hand, eliminating monthly video check-ins results in a 25% decrease in price. These options allow the consumer the freedom to pick a package that best fits their needs. It also allows for additional future upgrades for clients and may aid in increasing client retention by offering a lower-priced option that clients can downgrade to.

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching
Lesson 2Sales Goals and Process Customization

Sales Goals

As with most areas in life, goals are critical to creating a strong sales strategy. There are many different methods to set and track sales goals. This section will examine three different approaches to setting and tracking sales goals and provide reasonable recommendations for ensuring that goals are attainable and achieved. These approaches are defining sales goals, tracking sales, and prospecting clients.

Defining Sales Goals

Overall, a sales goal is an established revenue target or objective generated by program and service sales. Sales goals can be broken down into a virtually infinite number of subcategories to fit any business structure. However, the two most basic subcategories for defining sales goals are timeframe and sales stage. Sales goals can be broken down and tracked in three simple timeframes, including daily, weekly, and monthly.



FigureSales Goals

Three basic sales stages to be tracked include new **prospects**, **leads**, and **customers (Figure: Sales Goals)**. These goals represent the three different stages a customer enters during the sales cycle and will be expanded on later in this chapter. Using the timeline and sales stage method, the fitness professional now has three simple goals to track (**Table: Sales Goals Tracking**).

Sales Goals Tracking

Sales Goals	Daily	Weekly	Monthly
Prospects			
Leads			
Customers			

Prospect

A person whom the business has identified as fitting their client criteria but has not yet provided their information.

Leads

Prospects who have shown interest in a company and have provided identifying information, such as an email address.

Customers

Leads who have purchased a product or service from a company; may also be used interchangeably with the term *clients*.

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching
Lesson 2Sales Goals and Process Customization

Sales goals should be adjusted, at a minimum, on a quarterly basis to ensure the target numbers are not only realistic but are bringing in enough new clients to fulfill the fitness professional's vision for the business and financial need. The fitness professional can define the goals and timeframes that work best for their business; however, in this chapter, the above sales goals will be referenced and utilized for working examples.



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The sales goal tracking process can also be used for existing clients. For example, a fitness professional may create a goal to contact new clients after 30 days to see if they are interested in upgrading their virtual coaching package from training only to both nutrition and training. While these are existing clients in their respective categories of virtual coaching, they are leads for upgrading to a higher-priced service. It is always easier to sell to an existing client than it is to sell to a new client. Existing clients are already familiar with the business and less time and effort is needed to build trust and establish rapport compared to a potential customer.

Table: Sample Virtual Fitness Sales Goals illustrates how a simple sales goal process can potentially generate large amounts of consistent, predictable revenue for a business.

Sample Virtual Fitness Sales Goals

Sales Goals	**Daily**	**Weekly**	**Monthly**
Prospects	200	1,400	5,600
Leads	10	70	280
Customers	.4	3.4	14

Before the fitness professional has historical data to use for creating sales goals, all projections are educated guesses. For this example, it is assumed that 200 people per day will become prospects of the business. These prospects come from viewing the business's website, blogs, social media posts, etc. The example assumes that 5% of these prospects will turn into leads. The conversion from prospects to leads will change over time as leads do not go away after only 1 week. For example, in e-mail marketing, a lead may stay on a company's mailing list for months or years before becoming a customer. From these

leads, the assumption is made that 5% will convert to paid customers every month. Again, this number will change over time. It is the fitness professional's job to gradually improve the percentages of prospects, leads, and customer conversions. Incremental improvements add up over time.

This example used simple numbers and educated guesses for conversion rates. Sales and conversion goals must be updated regularly to align with financial need and provide the entrepreneur with the most realistic targets possible.

Tracking Sales

With sales goals established, the fitness professional must continually track their sales data to ensure realistic goals have been set. Using the metrics of daily, weekly, and monthly prospects, leads, and customers, the fitness entrepreneur has a powerful dataset for tracking sales and revenue. Each metric will have unique data points and places to source this data. To obtain sales data, the source of each metric being tracked must be clearly defined.

Each business should have personalized definitions of prospects, leads, and customers, but, in general, they will be similar to the following parameters for tracking. Prospects include unique views on the company website, comments on social media, podcast downloads, and video views. Prospects should be tracked daily. Leads include inbound e-mails and contact form submissions from the company website, direct messages on social media, inbound phone calls, downloading free ebooks in exchange for the lead's email address, and receiving any contact information from other means. Lead data will be tracked daily but recorded in the sales tracker weekly. Customers include anyone who has made their first purchase from the company or a client who returns after previously ending their services. For sales goals tracking, this number generally does not include those on recurring subscriptions. Customer data will be tracked daily but only recorded in the sales goal tracker monthly.



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Each sales stage category should be updated weekly with the previous week's data. This allows the fitness entrepreneur to track and stay on top of sales metrics and identify if they start to trend down, stay consistent, or trend upward. While nothing may need to be modified, it allows for visibility and tracking of revenue goals, and the fitness professional can determine how they may average out over time.

Helpful Hint

Just as declining sales are something the entrepreneur should be on alert for, explosive sales are also something to be aware of. Growth is vital for a business, but explosive growth is not sustainable for most small businesses and can have several negative consequences.

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching

Lesson 2Sales Goals and Process Customization

Tracking sales numbers should not be an overly complicated process and should not take more than a few minutes each day. The fitness professional may consider using the first 15 minutes of each day to record the previous day's numbers. A simple spreadsheet is all that is needed to accurately track sales goals. **Table: Example Virtual Sales Tracking Sheet** illustrates this process.

Example Virtual Sales Tracking Sheet

Day	Prospects	Leads	New Customers
1	1184	12	1
2	988	69	1
3	1132	91	6
4	1074	32	2
5	925	74	2
6	1231	12	0
7	1129	56	2
8	1080	22	2
9	800	48	4
10	1111	67	1
11	855	86	1
12	1164	93	8
13	919	28	1
14	942	75	2
15	814	8	1

16	937	84	3
17	1045	63	3
18	1086	109	4
19	995	100	4
20	966	58	5
21	856	9	0
22	924	37	3
23	1166	117	1
24	1151	104	4
25	1287	116	8
26	1221	37	3
27	1157	104	10
28	908	73	2
29	809	16	0
30	878	44	4
TOTALS	**30734**	**1841**	**88**
Averages	**1024**	**61**	**3**

Once data is gathered, it can be used to compare actual metric to projections. Using the data from the example provided, the business is surpassing the sales goals established in the previous section. This data can be used to readjust goals on a quarterly basis to ensure that trends are continuing in the right direction and that sales goals are realistic and achievable.

Prospecting for New Clients

Prospecting is the act of searching for new clients. Prospects turn into leads and leads turn into clients. Finding prospects can often be a challenging and intimidating aspect of sales for small business owners, typically with outbound sales or outbound prospecting. The method of cold-calling prospects from a purchased sales list, such as telemarketing, is typically no longer used. There are many ways to find prospects for leads and, ultimately, new clients. This section will focus on how to utilize the business's target audience, as defined in the business plan, and marketing plan to automate the prospecting process.



FigureCommon Sales Types

There are two types of sales: **business to consumer sales (B2C)** and **business to business sales (B2B) (Figure: Common Sales Types**). Fitness professionals who target the B2B market might be focused on services such as corporate wellness programs. In B2B marketing, the target customer is a business. Most virtual fitness professional's sales will fall into the B2C category, in which the target customer is an individual consumer. This section will focus primarily on the B2C category.

Prospecting, just like sales and marketing, can be broken down into inbound prospecting and outbound prospecting. **Inbound prospecting** builds on the marketing processes developed and will allow the prospecting process to become largely automated. An inbound prospect finds the company's content through various channels and content types defined in the marketing plan. These channels and content can include social media, search engines, pay-per-click (PPC) advertising, email marketing, videos, infographics, newsletters, etc. The goal is to convert the prospect who viewed or consumed the marketing content into a lead, and that lead in turn will provide the business with their contact information. This process will be discussed in greater detail later in this chapter. **Outbound prospecting** is when the target customer audience is first identified by the business and then, the business reaches out to the target customer and initiates contact. Outbound prospecting is an effective prospecting technique, but it is time-consuming and limits the ability to automate the prospecting process.

Prospecting must be continually performed, as businesses generally always need new customers. Prospecting can be developed and simplified into a repeatable and scalable process by focusing on three areas (**Figure: Prospecting Process**). First, clearly define the target market. Second, identify a clear prospecting strategy of how and where prospects will be found. Finally, establish a clear new prospecting strategy to ensure new prospects continue to become aware of the company.



FigureProspecting Process

Prospecting

Identifying potential customers.

Business to consumer sales (B2C)

Sales from a business directly to a person.

Business to business sales (B2B)

Sales from a business directly to another business.

Inbound prospecting

The process of a consumer discovering a business from passive content released by the business.

Outbound prospecting

The process of a business contacting a consumer via direct marketing.

Define Target Market

The first step in automating the prospecting process is to ensure the target market, or target audience, is well-defined. This should be clearly outlined in the business plan, as the target market is used for many different areas of the business, including but not limited to sales and marketing. When defining or refining the target market for use in sales prospecting, the virtual fitness professional should ask three questions. **Please note:** This is not an all-inclusive list of questions, but it is a great starting point.



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Sales Strategy Questions for Define Target Market



1. What is the ideal client's goal?
2. How old is the ideal client?
3. How long is the average client enrolled in coaching?

Building on these three questions, the fitness professional can then focus their prospecting efforts on a narrower demographic.

Prospecting Strategy

The second step in automating the prospecting process is developing a strategy for how the business will find new prospects. An example outbound prospecting strategy would be to purchase a list of consumers who fit the target audience and then, either call or e-mail them. This is a time consuming and expensive process, which typically yields poor results.

Utilizing an inbound prospecting approach, the virtual fitness entrepreneur can take advantage of the marketing plan and capitalize on existing content to attract prospective clients. For example, utilizing blog posts that have followed a strategic search engine optimization (SEO) approach, as defined by the marketing strategy, will bring in consumers who are in the business's target audience directly to the company's website. These prospects are very high quality because they qualified themselves into the target audience by searching for a question the business can, and already has, answered in their blog post content.

Sales Strategy Questions for Prospecting Strategy



The fitness professional can define how the business will obtain new prospects by answering three questions.

1. Based on the marketing strategy, what are the top three content types that will be utilized by the business to attract prospects (videos, infographics, blogs, podcasts, etc.)?
2. For each of the content marketing types identified, what incentive will be created and offered for the consumer to share their contact information with the business and become a lead?
3. For each incentive, how will the fitness business entrepreneur follow up with the newly created lead? How can this process be automated?

Coach's Corner

The prospecting strategy must focus on refining the content marketing strategy to ensure content developed is directed toward the target audience.

For example, if a fitness professional's target audience is older adults, they may write blog posts about protein intake for seniors. The prospecting strategy should ensure that the blog is optimized for commonly used terms the prospects will type into a search engine.

If the business is utilizing videos in their marketing, the prospecting strategy should ensure the videos offer an incentive for prospects to provide their contact information and become leads.

A well-rounded business needs to have prospects and, consequently, sales coming from more than one place. Having multiple sales pipelines will ensure the business has enough diversity and a strong foundation of prospects that can withstand market changes over time.

New Prospects Strategy

The third step in developing and automating the prospecting process is reading a new prospecting strategy. This ensures there is a constant flow of new prospects into the sales pipeline. While content creation is an integral part of the marketing strategy, it is equally, if not more important, for the prospecting strategy. To ensure a steady stream of prospects, content must be created on a regular and consistent basis and focus on topics the target audience is actively seeking knowledge on. For example, a blog post that covers how to design home workouts may appeal perfectly to the target audience. However, if the blog content is three years old and does not consider the latest home fitness equipment, the previous impact the blog may have had is lost and fewer leads will be generated from the outdated content. On the other hand, publishing and promoting monthly blog posts reviewing the latest home exercise equipment will produce new and different prospects regularly.



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Sales Plan Questions for New Prospects Strategy



1. Referring to the three types of content marketing identified previously, how often will content be created for each type of content?
2. How often will incentives offered to the prospect be updated?
3. How can prospects, leads, and clients be incentivized to bring new prospects into the business? (List at least one idea for each.)

Now that the entrepreneur has a well-defined prospecting strategy, they can start building a repeatable and scalable process that can be automated using e-mail marketing and content creation and building a referral network from potential, existing, and former clients.

Getting Technical

Marketing automation is essential to a growing business. Consider searching for and reviewing articles for additional information about various marketing automation tools on the market.

23 Marketing Automation Tools You Need to Use (Patel, 2020)

The Best Email Marketing Software for 2020 (McLaughlin & Sevilla, 2020)

Customizing the Sales Process

With an automated prospecting process, the fitness professional can provide a highly customized sales process designed to appeal to different subsets of their target market. The process of subdividing target markets is called market segmentation. Segmenting a marketing or sales list will allow the fitness professional to deliver highly customized and personalized sales messaging directly to leads.

Email list segmentation can be implemented starting at the prospect level. Specific marketing content can be created for different segments of the target audience. For example, a blog post about resistance training for busy mothers will attract a different segment of the same target audience when compared to a blog post about endurance training for busy mothers. The target audience is the same, but the segments, those interested in resistance training versus those interested in endurance training, are different.

Segmenting the target audience can be automated for the sales process when the prospect becomes a lead by providing their email address in exchange for an offer. The lead is then segmented into an appropriate email marketing list that contains the same basic information as other email workflows but will have more personalized sales copy that conveys an understanding and solution to the segment's problems.



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Educating Prospective Clients

The purpose of the marketing strategy is to educate prospective clients about the existence of the company and its programs and services. The sales process continues educating leads about the solutions the fitness professional provides to the problems they are facing. This education should be customized to a lead's segment as much as possible. Every lead will prefer to be educated on the aspects of the programs or services that directly apply to their individual needs. Two education techniques include offering a unique selling proposition and value proposition.

Offering a Unique Selling Proposition

A unique selling proposition (USP) is a specific benefit a product or service provides the target market that separates a business from its competitors. It is important to highlight the true uniqueness of the programs and services offered. Mentioning features of a business or its services is simply not enough. There was a time when responding to an e-mail within 24 hours or offering text messaging to a client was unique and rare. However, at a time when more online coaching businesses are appearing, these features have now become the standard. The fitness business entrepreneur needs a USP that only they are able to bring to their clients. While the USP can be the same for different lead segments, it should be positioned differently to address the unique concerns of a particular segment.

Providing Value

The value proposition is simply the value of the programs and services that are offered. This can describe the price of the service, service quality, and value trade-off, which is the lead saving money by choosing the service offered instead of spending more money on another option. Value propositions should educate leads on the value of the programs or services and be utilized to support the USP.

Customer Onboarding Process

Developing a systematic process around the customer sales cycle or sales strategy allows for tracking, refinement, directional pivots, reproducibility/scale, and efficiency in client acquisition. Prior to becoming paid clients, consumers will enter different stages based on where they are in the sales process. As mentioned previously, these sales stages are prospects, leads, and clients.

Prospects are potential customers who are just finding out about the service. This could be by reading a blog, watching a video, or simply browsing the fitness professional's website. Prospects are starting to show interest in the business's services; however, they have shown no interest beyond that.

Leads are prospects who have shown a greater-than-normal interest in the business's product or service. Typically, a lead has reached out to the fitness professional in some form and has provided some type of personal information to initiate interaction and conversation. This contact information can come from filling out a form on the fitness professional's website, entering an e-mail address in exchange for a free ebook, or interacting with the fitness professional on social media.

Customers or clients are leads who have become paid customers of the business. Once a person becomes a client, they do not simply stay at this stage. Existing clients can also re-enter a sales funnel and become a lead for service or product upgrades and add-ons. Clients need to be nurtured as much, if not more, than prospects and leads to ensure their retention.

Please note: Both prospects and leads can become clients—they do not have to follow the specific order or progression outlined to become a client. The prospect, lead, and customer path is simply the most common progression from consumer to paid customer.

Prospect

A person whom the business has identified as fitting their client criteria but has not yet provided their information.

Leads

Prospects who have shown interest in a company and have provided identifying information, such as an email address.

Customers

Leads who have purchased a product or service from a company; may also be used interchangeably with the term clients.

Customer Journey

The fitness business entrepreneur should develop an understanding of what their client's customer journey will be as they progress from prospect to client. This journey or process can also be referred to as the sales funnel. Mapping the customer journey will allow the fitness professional to develop a repeatable process that can be modified based on real-world results and feedback. The customer journey will tie in closely with marketing efforts. The sales aspect of the customer journey will essentially be an expanded and more detailed outline derived from the fitness professional's marketing strategy.

An important aspect of the **customer journey process** is dividing potential customers into different subcategories. Separating prospects into groups based on certain predetermined characteristics is called market segmentation. **Market segmentation** allows the fitness professional to build more effective sales strategies based on consumer characteristics and where a prospect is in their customer journey. A potential client who visits one blog on a company's website needs a different marketing strategy than a potential client who follows a call to action and provides their e-mail address in exchange for a free ebook.

Using a fictitious company, here is an example of a possible customer journey map (**Figure: Customer Journey Map**):



FigureCustomer Journey Map

1. A **consumer** reads a blog article the fitness professional posted and becomes a **prospect**.
    - How the prospect found the blog article is detailed in the marketing strategy and may include paid search engine advertising, social media sharing, and organic search results.
    - Other content examples that may be used to drive prospect engagement include blogs, videos, infographics, social media posts, and podcasts.
2. The **prospect** provides their contact information to the business and is turned into a **lead**.
    - The incentive for the prospect to provide this information is a detail from the marketing strategy by following a **call to action**.
    - Content that can be used to turn a prospect into a lead include free digital content offers (training template, webinars, ebooks, etc.), filling out a contact form, or interacting with the business on social media.
3. The **lead** is nurtured and turned into a **client**.

- Lead nurturing is a tie-in between marketing and sales. Details about how leads will be nurtured are provided from the marketing strategy. No matter the lead nurturing strategy, the sales goal is the same.
- Examples of lead nurturing include automated e-mail marketing campaigns, phone calls, and text messaging.

Customer journey process

The guided path, designed by the business, that a consumer will follow to turn into a customer.

Market segmentation

Dividing prospects and leads to more well-defined categories.

Call to action

A prompt from a business for a consumer to take an action.

While this is a basic example of the journey from prospect to client, not all prospects will become leads and not all leads will become clients. If a prospect does not provide a business with contact information, that does not automatically mean they cannot become a lead at some point in the future. A lead can be subdivided into two categories: warm and hot lead. A **warm lead** does not provide the business with contact information. However, the business can use paid advertising to initiate a **retargeting campaign** and subsequent sales funnel.

A **hot lead** is a client who has provided the business with their contact information in exchange for an offer from the company, as mentioned in previous examples. When a hot lead drops off and stops responding, they can be placed into yet another sales funnel that perhaps offers a discount on the program or service or even a free trial to further incentivize the lead into accepting a call to action. In this situation, the additional offer helps to continue building trust and rapport with the lead.

Sales Plan Questions for Customer Journey Process



1. What are three types of content that can be used to attract prospects? How can the content be created and managed?
2. What are two types of free, high-quality content that can be used to turn prospects into leads? What offer will be presented to the prospect in exchange for their contact information.
3. What are two methods in which leads will be nurtured into clients? What is your lead nurturing process?

Warm lead

A lead that is interested but has not provided the business with contact information.

Retargeting campaign

A marketing campaign that targets specific segments of prospects or leads that have not yet become customers.

Hot lead

A lead that is interested and has provided the business with contact information.

From Client to Brand Champion

For many businesses, once a prospect becomes a client, the sales process is over. The customer journey process has achieved its goal and the business has a new client. However, for the fitness professional entrepreneur, the process has only just begun. Because it is easier and more cost-effective to sell to existing customers compared to acquiring new customers, the fitness professional should focus on maximizing a **customer's lifetime value (CLV)**. This can be done through delivering exceptional service, product add-ons, and upgrades. Upgrading a client who enrolled in online fitness training to online training plus nutrition coaching will result in a more profitable customer while also providing the customer with more tools to achieve their goals and overall success.

Food for Thought

Imagine that a client pays $200 per month for virtual fitness coaching. Assuming that the client has an average membership length of 4 months, the lifetime value of this client is $800. If this client upgrades to a package that includes virtual fitness and nutrition coaching at $250 per month, after their first month, the client has a lifetime value of $950. This is a 16% increase in revenue from the client’s original lifetime value. Over the course of a year, if 100 clients purchase the same upgrade, this would result in an extra $15,000 in revenue for the business.

Upgrading an existing client's services is yet another customer journey process. The previous customer journey examined turning a prospect into a client; however, turning an existing client into a brand champion client requires a different process. A champion is a client who has a higher than average CLV. The brand champion client is a champion of your business and your brand. They are a long-term client who purchases service upgrades and raves about the business to everyone they know. Not every client will become a brand champion, but the virtual fitness entrepreneur must have processes in place to be able to take clients to the champion level.

Customer lifetime value (CLV)

The amount that a customer will spend with business over a lifetime.

A referral program can be a great way to turn clients into champions. A referral program is a relatively easy sales process to automate. A referral program can be as simple as sending an automated e-mail to all clients every 30 days informing them that for every three clients they refer to the business, they will receive 1 month of virtual coaching free. This simple method can turn successful clients into salespeople for the business. For example, if the business has 100 clients at an average CLV of $800 each, obtaining three referrals from just 5% of existing clients would potentially result in an $11,000 per year profit, simply by sending an e-mail.

The final customer journey that will be illustrated is that of the former client. Every business should target former clients. Former clients are already familiar with the business and can be considered a warm lead because they have already provided their contact information and paid for programs or services previously. Again, basic e-mail automation can simplify this process for the already busy virtual fitness professional. Re-engaging former clients can be as simple as sending them an e-mail every 60 days to check-in, see how they are doing, and offer a 10% discount if they return to virtual training or coaching. As an example, if just 5% of a list of 500 former clients re-enroll in coaching per year, assuming an average CLV of $800 ($200 per month x 4 months), the business will have increased its annual revenue by $20,000 simply by sending an e-mail.



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The customer journey is not just one process but many depending on where the customer, client, or former client are currently in their lifetime cycle with the fitness professional. The fitness professional entrepreneur who establishes processes that cover every aspect possible of a customer’s journey has set up their business for steady growth and long-term success.

Sales Process

The **sales process** is what happens after a prospect becomes a lead. The sales process is the journey that leads take to become paying clients. During the previous phase of prospecting for new clients, the consumer turned into a lead. At that point, the marketing process ended, and the sale process began.

The lead-to-client sales process is one that will illustrate to qualified leads that the fitness professional understands their needs, help build rapport, and show the potential client their concerns and desires are being heard. This allows the fitness professional to demonstrate their expertise in the area the lead is struggling with. This process is commonly referred to as **lead nurturing**. In an automated sales process, lead nurturing can easily be done via e-mail marketing.

With e-mail marketing automation, the fitness professional has the equivalent of highly personalized ads sent directly to their target audience who has already shown specific interest in their products or services. E-mail automation provides the fitness professional with an opportunity to perform market segmentation and provide highly personalized e-mails. E-mail automation should always be as segmented as possible to ensure the most personalized messaging possible is being delivered to the lead.



Eny Setiyowati/Shutterstock.com

Not everyone on a fitness professional's e-mail marketing list is a lead. When someone is first added to an e-mail list, they are a lead. This means the marketing strategy used by the fitness professional worked and a prospect was turned into a lead. The prospect showed interest, accepted an offer, and opted-in to an e-mail list and became a lead. The lead is then placed into e-mail automation software and enters into a specific e-mail automation workflow for new leads. This **workflow** is designed to provide e-mails that will build rapport and increase trust with leads. This is typically done over several days or weeks. By the time the workflow is complete, one of three things will happen:

1. **The lead becomes a client.** The workflow was successful. Once the lead becomes a client, the new lead workflow ends immediately.
2. **The lead unsubscribes from the workflow.** This can happen for any number of reasons. **Please note:** If the unsubscribe rate is more than .3% on the initial e-mail, then the content of the e-mails in the workflow should be assessed/re-examined for relevancy. Any of the following can influence open

and unsubscribe rates and should be examined: the subject line copy, e-mail body copy, frequency or quantity of e-mails, day and/or time sent, and content design reassessed.

3. **The workflow ends and the lead does not become a client.** The sales process did not work and the lead did not initiate a purchase.

In the outcome where the lead did not become a client, they are no longer a lead but are once again a prospect. They will still receive general marketing e-mails as part of the marketing strategy; however, they would no longer receive personalized lead nurturing e-mails. At this point, the prospect will need to be remarketed to until they are placed into another sales funnel or workflow.

Sales process

The journey of turning a lead into a client.

Lead nurturing

The process of educating, displaying empathy, understanding, and listening to a lead to turn the lead into a customer.

Workflow

A systematic and repeatable process.

Sales Process Example

Imagine a prospect has entered the sales process after providing their e-mail address on the company's website in exchange for a free ebook. Instantly, the newly created lead receives this email in their inbox.

Email 1

Subject: No Frustration Home Workouts

Body:

Hi, Joe,

Many people think that working out at home requires expensive equipment, a lot of room, and time that they just don't have. You're about to find out that none of that is true. As requested, this email contains your free access to an at-home fitness guide that will show you how to design easy home workouts without expensive equipment in any sized space and in time increments that you can manage.

Download ***Self-Guided Home Workouts*** here.

Please reach out to me at any time with any questions that you have.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

P.S. I will send you an email tomorrow covering the most common questions that I receive about the ebook.

The email containing the ebook download was sent immediately to the new lead, helping build trust by delivering on the promise made. The email addresses the lead by name, reminds the lead about how the offer (ebook download) can help solve a problem, and then delivers the solution by providing the ebook. At the bottom of the email are the next steps, which indicate they will receive an email the following day that contains answers to some of the most common questions regarding the ebook topics.

This initial e-mail accomplishes the following goals:

- Builds trust
- Shows an understanding of the problem the client wants to solve
- Provides a solution and evidence of expertise in the problem area (e-book)

- Outlines expectations for next steps
- Demonstrates a genuine interest in the lead with the follow-up Q & A email

Exactly 24 hours later, the next email is sent.

Email 2

Subject: Answers to Your Questions, as Promised

Body:

Hi, Joe,

"Working out is difficult and time consuming." This is the most common issue that I hear as a virtual fitness coach. Many people don't feel like they have the time or skill to work out effectively from home. However, the truth is that anyone can work out effectively from home and achieve the results they want. As I mentioned in yesterday's e-mail, here are the most common questions I receive:

Q: What if I'm not strong enough to do some of the exercises like a pushup?

A: Eventually, you will be. With consistency, patience, and practice, you'll be able to do a push-up in no time. Until you can, you can modify any exercise so that you're able to perform it (more on how to modify exercises shortly).

Q: How long should these home workouts take?

A: There is no set amount of time to work out. If you're able to work out for 45 minutes at once, perfect. If you're only able to work out in two 5-minute intervals per day, then that is perfect too.

Q: How long will it take for me to see results?

A: That will vary by person. However, there are ways to get noticeable results much faster than others. In fact, that's why I offer online fitness coaching with completely custom designed exercise and nutrition coaching to get you the results that you want and need. If you're interested in learning more about teaming up with me for online coaching, click this link to schedule a free 20-minute phone consultation.

If the ebook yesterday made you feel a little overwhelmed with designing your own home workout, that's fine! Here is an example of a home workout that I designed for a client. This workout lists the modifications for exercises in case you have some difficulty with them at first. Give this workout a try tomorrow and I will check-in in 2 days to see how it went.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

P.S. I'll also be sending you my free nutrition guide in the next email. So, make sure you keep an eye out for the email!

The second email was delivered exactly when promised, as indicated in the subject line. It begins with an objection that is broad, but one that people genuinely have about fitness training. The email then proceeds to present the lead with an additional offer to accept/opt-into a free workout to try at home. Finally, the email ends again with a clearly defined next step. The fitness professional will check-in two days after the lead completed the workout. The email also incentivizes the lead to open the follow-up email because there is another free guide coming, only this time focused on nutrition, as well as a surprise bonus.

Two days later, the lead receives the next email.

Email 3

Subject: How Did Everything Go?

Body:

Hi, Joe,

How was your workout?

If you thought the workouts were too hard, you can modify the example by performing 1/2 of the workout one day and the other half the next day. Over the next week, attempt to complete the entire workout in one session. Alternatively, you can still take me up on that offer for a free consultation by **scheduling** here.

If you felt the workouts were too easy or not challenging enough, you can perform the workout twice in one session and increase the number of rounds you complete per training session.

As promised, here is the **free nutrition guide**. Give it a read tonight (it's only 10 pages), perform the workout routine again, and I will check-in tomorrow.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

The third email is again, delivered as promised. This email starts out with a question of concern, such as "How was your workout?" and immediately provides the two most common answers, easy or difficult, followed by a solution for each of those answers. The solution for those answers is the sales offer, which is located toward the beginning of the email. Finally, the next step is clearly laid out. The lead will hear from the fitness professional tomorrow after they have had an opportunity to read the nutrition guide as well as perform the bonus workout they just received.

The next day, the lead receives another email.

Email 4

Subject: You Have the Tools. Do You Need A Guide?

Body:

Joe,

Over the past few days, your fitness toolbox has grown. First, you received a book that showed you how to design your own personalized home workouts. Then, we covered the most common questions and went over an example workout that you performed. Finally, we covered the basics of nutrition yesterday with your free nutrition guide. (If you have questions on that, please reply to this email and let's cover them!) So, what's next?

If you're still slightly confused, nervous, or unsure, I'd like to offer you 20% off of my online fitness coaching. I only make this offer one time to all customers and only for 48 hours. Why, you ask? To help motivate you! Now is the time to make the changes you want to make. There is no reason to wait longer. If you're serious about change, I want to help you out as much as possible.

You can **click here** to view all of the options I offer and to enroll in coaching. When you're checking out, use the promo code JOE123 and you'll receive your 20% off.

Don't wait, Joe! Remember that this offer expires in 48 hours. I won't e-mail you until after the offer expires, so make sure you enroll now if you're interested.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

The fourth email starts off by reminding the lead of what they have already received and then offers a 20% discount on their first month of coaching. Finally, there is a sales opportunity, which is reasonable and not forceful. There is a limited amount of time to accept the offer and an explanation of why the offer expiration exists. The final line of the email states they will not hear from the fitness professional again until the offer expires.

Twenty-four hours after the promotional offer expires, the lead receives the final email in the sales workflow.

Email 5

Subject: What Are Your Plans?

Body:

Joe,

It's been 3 days since I emailed you about enrolling in coaching and you haven't enrolled. Please tell me about your concerns or fears in enrolling. I understand that enrolling is a big step, but I'd love to help you make that step towards investing in your health. I'd like to make one final offer, and, after this, I promise I'll stop sending these almost daily emails to you.

If you're really interested in making a change in your life and achieving your goals, talk to me. Call me, text me, email me. My number is 312-867-5309. Contact me anytime. If I'm unable to answer, leave a voicemail and I'll call you back. I promise that I will get back to you as soon as possible. We're in this together and I'm on your team. There is no reason to go at it alone. Just send a simple text that says "Hi" and we'll start from there.

John Smith, NASM-CPT

Virtual Fitness Coach

The final email begins by reminding the client that they missed the offer. They are then asked clearly what their concerns are for investing in coaching. This is followed by a call to action asking for their input which demonstrates the fitness professional is listening and wants to understand the lead's perspective.

After the final email in the workflow, if the lead has not become a client, they return to being categorized as a prospect.

A quality e-mail automation software will provide significant analytics for the fitness business entrepreneur to analyze and use to improve each section of their e-mail communications, from subject lines, to copy, to images used, and the design of the e-mail (Zote, 2020).

Table: Common E-Mail Marketing Statistics outlines common e-mail marketing statistics across all industries (Mailchimp, n.d.).

Common Email Marketing Statistics

Average Open Rate	Average Click Rate	Unsubscribe Rate
21.33%	2.62%	0.26%

Using these industry average stats as a starting point, the fitness professional can adjust each e-mail in their workflow to improve open, average click, and unsubscribe rates. **Please note:** It is normal for open rates to decline further into the workflow. The following example sales workflow contains five e-mails, provides the lead with ample opportunities to ask questions, and contains numerous trust- and rapport-building qualities.



FigureSample Email Sales Workflow

Sales Email Techniques

There are many ways to structure and draft sales e-mails. The following sections will provide additional recommendations for sales e-mails, including uncovering needs, building rapport, and listening. Each of these techniques will help the fitness professional establish themselves as a credible expert in the virtual coaching arena.

Uncovering Needs

Each client has different needs. When marketing to a wide range of people in an automated process, the need being addressed must be comprehensive. The best need for sales e-mails to address can be uncovered through surveys and feedback from those leads that end up turning into clients. Existing clients are invaluable sales tools. Initially, the fitness professional will be using their knowledge of the industry and target market to develop their sales e-mails. However, after a successful client leaves their virtual coaching program, the fitness professional entrepreneur can survey former clients about what they found the most helpful about coaching. This feedback can be used to build a more accurate list of common needs virtual coaching can fulfill for clients. These needs can then be addressed in sales e-mails to demonstrate that the fitness professional understands the lead's pain points.

To begin uncovering leads' needs, the fitness professional can ask the following questions:

1. What are the three most common goals training clients start with?
2. What challenges did the client face that lead them to desire those goals?
3. What is one way to demonstrate empathy for each of the challenges the client faced?

These questions can also be reworded and asked to former clients in an exit survey.

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching
Lesson 3The Onboarding Process

Building Rapport

Building rapport with consumers is not an easy task. Consumers largely distrust marketing, and this puts the fitness professional in a more difficult position as they attempt to build a long and meaningful relationship with their clients. The fitness professional will need to be positioned not only as an authority in the eyes of the consumer but also be perceived as genuine and authentic. Being genuine, honest, and truthful in the marketing content will build rapport with the consumer before they even contact the fitness professional or business.

The rapport a business builds with a consumer begins the instant the consumer becomes aware of the business. This awareness can come from many sources, including advertising, blogs, social media posts, and even word of mouth. Prior to obtaining a client's e-mail address, a business must start to build a positive rapport with a prospect. This positive rapport can be established relatively easily by providing free, high-quality content used in marketing and then presenting an offer to the prospect in exchange for their e-mail address. Because of the rapport established during the marketing process, a prospect should have little objection to providing their contact information in exchange for higher-quality, higher-value content. The offer that is immediately presented to the newly created lead fulfills the promise made and further enhances positive rapport.

Throughout the entire sales email workflow, the fitness professional needs to demonstrate that they are an authority, genuine, and authentic throughout the sales email workflow. In addition, it should be obvious that they understand the issues the lead is facing and that the information being provided will start to solve those issues.

Sales Strategy Questions for Building Rapport



1. How will the business position themselves as an authority by the second sales e-mail?
2. How will authenticity be demonstrated and maintained throughout the sales process?
3. What is one example of how a genuine concern for the lead's issues will be demonstrated?

Listening

With in-person training, the client and fitness professional have face-to-face interactions that allow for more opportunities to listen to a client's needs, desires, and concerns. This face-to-face interaction is largely lost with virtual training. Interaction through e-mail, texting, and, to a lesser-extent, video conferencing do not provide the same opportunities for conversation that exist with in-person training.

However, a fitness professional can overcome this obstacle in marketing and sales e-mails by preemptively addressing common objections, asking specific questions of the leads, as well as asking leads to reach out with any questions of their own.

Sales Strategy Questions for Listening



1. What are three common objections to virtual coaching? What response could be given to those objections.
2. What are three creative ways that leads can be encouraged to ask questions about coaching?
3. What are the three most common questions leads and new clients ask?

Billing and Collecting Payment

As with almost all aspects of a business, an efficient billing and payment processing system must aim to simplify things for the customer. A fitness business entrepreneur should strive for automation and repeatable processes and avoid needless redundancy. Billing and payment processing systems can seem overwhelming to those with non-technical backgrounds, but there are many affordable and less-technical options available on the market. This section will cover several points to consider when selecting a billing and payment processing system.

Selecting a Merchant Processor

Companies that provide billing services to businesses are called **merchant processors** or payment processors. These processors provide the business with simple solutions for accepting credit card payments on their website. Prior to a processor accepting a new business, the business will need at least three key items: a business license, an employer identification number, and a business checking account (**Figure: Procure Processor**).

Items Needed to Procure a Merchant or Billing Processor



FigureProcure Processor

1. Business license for the state in which the business was formed
2. Federal **Employer Identification Number (EIN)**
    - The EIN functions much like a social security number for a business. An EIN can be applied for at no cost on the IRS website.
    - Many companies offer to obtain an EIN number for a business for a fee, but this can easily be completed by the fitness professional.
3. Business checking account
    - The fitness professional must have a business checking account and not a consumer bank account in the business owner's name. Depending on the type of business formed, this can have different tax consequences.

Note that not all of these are related to sales, but they are important items that every business needs.

Merchant processors

Businesses that process credit card payments for another business.

Chapter 8Selling Virtual Coaching
Lesson 4Billing and Collecting Payment

When comparing merchant processors, several different options should be evaluated. The one that provides features and services that best meet the needs of the fitness professional should be chosen. If the fitness professional is less technologically savvy, then a processor that offers simplicity when integrating with a website may be best. If the fitness professional requires advanced analytics, then they will need to ensure that they have a processor that offers integrations with various software applications and that exports sufficient types and quantities of data. Processors typically charge a small percentage of the sale that the business pays. These fees vary slightly depending on the processor or plan selected, but typically range from 2.6% to 3.2% + 30¢ per transaction.

Helpful Hint

Unless the business is generating millions of dollars in sales per year, price should not be a large consideration when looking for a processor. If a business performed $1 million in business over 5,000 transactions per year, the difference is $6,000 and may not be worth the time put into price shopping payment processors.

Key Things to Look for and Consider When Searching for a Payment Processor

1. Fees ranging from 2.6% to 3.2% + 30¢ per transaction
2. The ability to setup subscriptions and recurring client payments
3. Daily deposits of funds
4. Well-known and established company
5. Ease of access to customer service

Once the payment processor is properly set up, the fitness professional entrepreneur can focus on setting up an automated billing and payment system for clients.

E-Commerce System

With a virtual coaching business, the business's store is the company website. There is no physical location for a client to come into and ask questions. A business's website is not only its marketing home but is also the company's sales desk. A virtual coaching business needs to allow clients to purchase and immediately enroll in coaching, without face-to-face interaction with the fitness professional. A website that requires a potential client to wait for the fitness professional to contact them in order to enroll in coaching is increasing the steps and, subsequently, barriers to purchase. An e-commerce website should provide a clear path to virtual coaching, from basic information all the way to registration and payment.

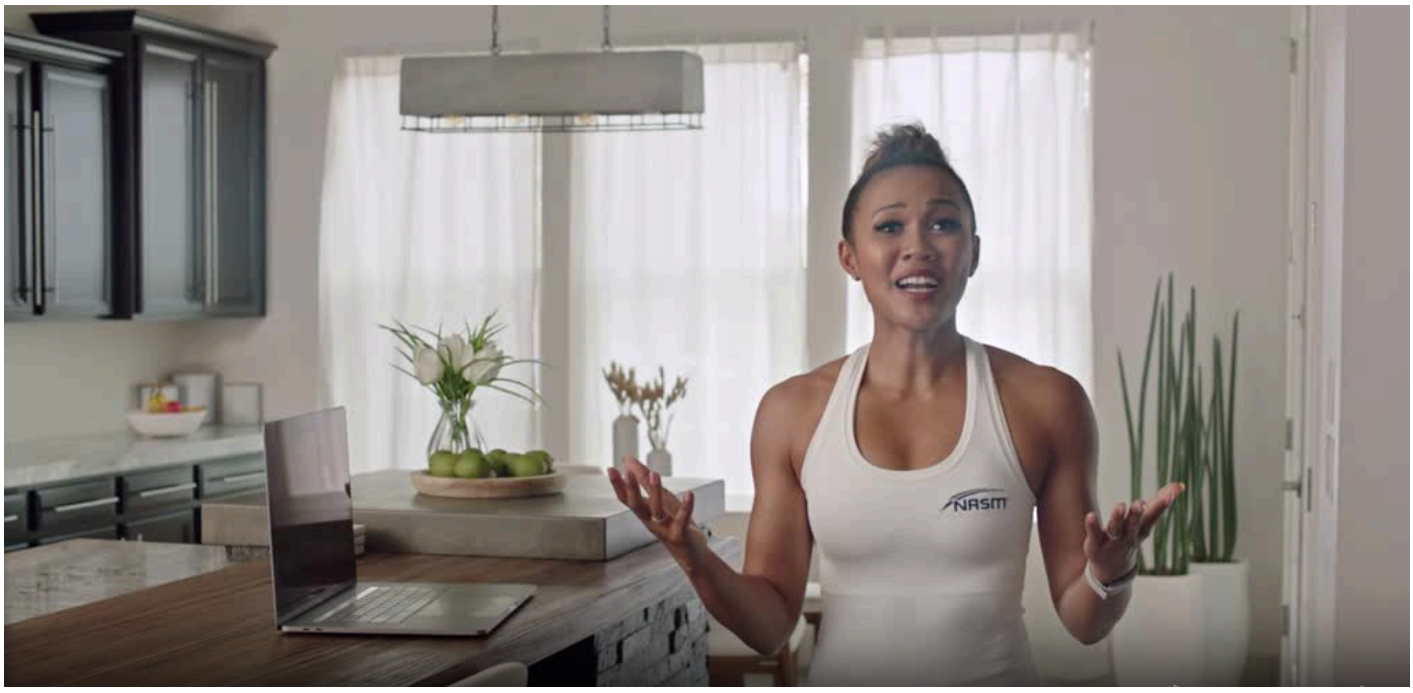
Collecting Online Payments

With recurring payments, the business must collect payments monthly and on time. If payment is collected too early, a client's budget may not allow the payment to process. If payment is collected too late, a client may be receiving free coaching, even if they do not intend to continue. Having consistent, automated billing also allows for the fitness professional to have predictable and consistent revenue coming into the business. Allowing a client to enter their own billing information into a website and subscribe to coaching via an online e-commerce platform integrated with the business's merchant processor will allow payments and subscription fees to be automated. Sending out individual invoices to clients every month is time consuming and allows for potential errors in amounts billed and consistency in payments. Automated billing and payment processing take stress away from the fitness professional, allowing them to focus on more impactful activities such as content development, programming, and coaching.

Summary

Like any small business owner, a fitness professional who owns a virtual coaching business has roles and responsibilities that extend beyond developing programs and coaching clients, such as marketing their services and generating sales. Sales are vital to a company's success. Without sales, there is no revenue and without revenue, there is no company. While focusing on sales is often viewed with a negative connotation, it does not have to be. Ethical sales strategies and techniques are rooted in educating and helping others. It, ultimately, comes down to identifying potential clients' needs, offering solutions to those needs, and then asking them to make a financial commitment for those solutions. The aspects of running a business that can be automated should be, as automation frees up time to focus on areas of the business that cannot be and are vital to establishing authority, credibility, and authenticity in the market, such as content development, programming, and coaching and serving clients.

Marketing and sales processes can largely be automated and when combined with proper market segmentation, allows for personalized messaging delivered directly into the hands, and eyes, of the business's target audience. Automated sales workflows leveraging e-mail can be customized to not only deliver highly impactful content to potential clients but can also be used to contact existing customers about service add-ons and upgrades and re-engage former clients in an attempt to build another meaningful relationship. Please refer to the video below for a summary of the topics discussed within this chapter.





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